

2003

Got a full-scale banking licence to tap the low-cost deposits and broad base assets or loans offering

2008

Entered the asset reconstruction business to buy and resolve bad loans

2014

Merger of ING Vysya with the bank; also forayed into general insurance

2017

Bought microfinance businesses of BSS

Microfinance to serve the bottom of the pyramid

2020

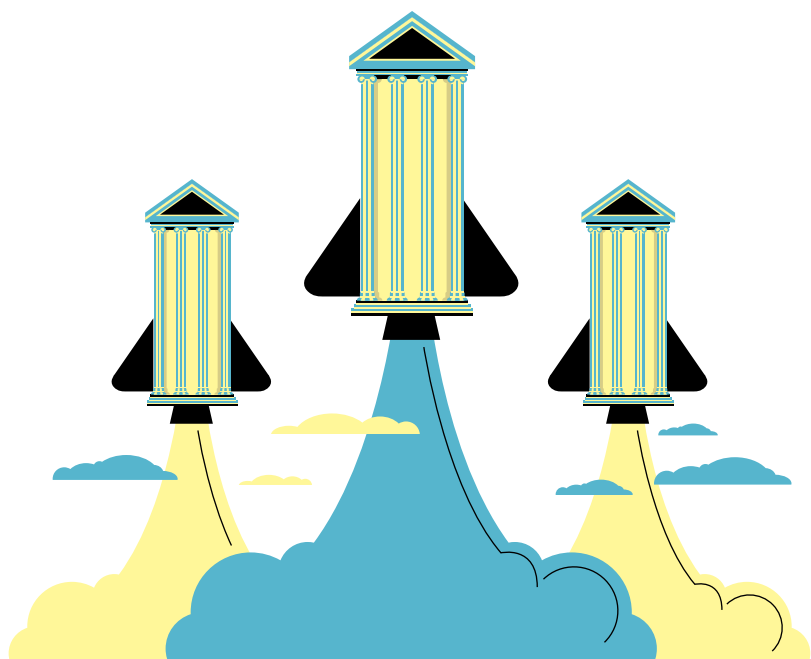
Launched first digital offering, Digital video KYC, to open savings and other banking accounts

2022

Started Kotak Cherry, a start-up venture in the BFSI space

2023

Bought microfinance business from Sonata Finance



ILLUSTRATIONS BY RAJ VERMA

improve productivity. Kotak made senior-level lateral hires in tech, customer experience, marketing, branding, data, and risk analytics.

So, Milind Nagnur, a veteran of JPMorgan, Citibank, and Wells Fargo, came in as Chief Technology Officer. Bhavnish Lathia came in from Amazon's Seattle headquarters as Chief of Customer Experience and Head of Technology. Rohit

Bhasin from FMCG giant Unilever is the Head of Retail Liabilities Product and Chief Marketing Officer, while Bhaskar Kumar, from GE Capital, HSBC, and Bajaj Finserv, is the Chief Risk Officer. Heading HR is Anupam Kaura, from CRISIL, London. Ashok Vaswani, the "global banker", joined as MD & CEO.

The succession at Kotak involved a transition from a founder-

professional to a pure professional, something like what was seen at Infosys. This succession is different from ICICI, HDFC, or IndusInd, where the professional who built the foundation of the bank is no longer associated with the bank. Kotak has a seat on the board to guide the new team.

Kotak is aware of emerging concerns in banking, such as the shift from savers (banking) to investors (stock market). "When the movement happens from savers to investors, what it normally does—and you can see it in individual behaviour—is that many individuals have moved their money away from deposits to investments, particularly equity investments. This is good because you are building risk capital," explains Kotak. At the same time, he says, governance must be top-notch, and liquidity in stocks broad-based.

In his last letter to shareholders, Kotak mentioned global institutions that he wants his group to emulate. He cited JP Morgan, the world's largest bank by market capitalisation, founded by John Morgan, run later by his son J.P. Morgan and then by professional CEOs.

Uday Kotak, like J.P. Morgan, has bet his name to develop a long-lasting institution. "I have always believed an institution is more important than an individual, and institutions must go on forever. Individuals may come and go, and that is a core philosophy I deeply believe in. That is what we are really working on," says Kotak.

And he is not done yet. As Mahindra wrote on X, "Uday's simply starting a new chapter of impact on the Indian Financial Services Industry. Here's to more adventures, my friend." **BT**

@anandadhikari